

The Saudi Workforce Deployment Playbook for EPCM Firms

How EPCM firms can get critical engineering and mining specialists employed, cleared and ready to work in Saudi Arabia without workforce deployment slowing the project.

THE DELIVERY RISK

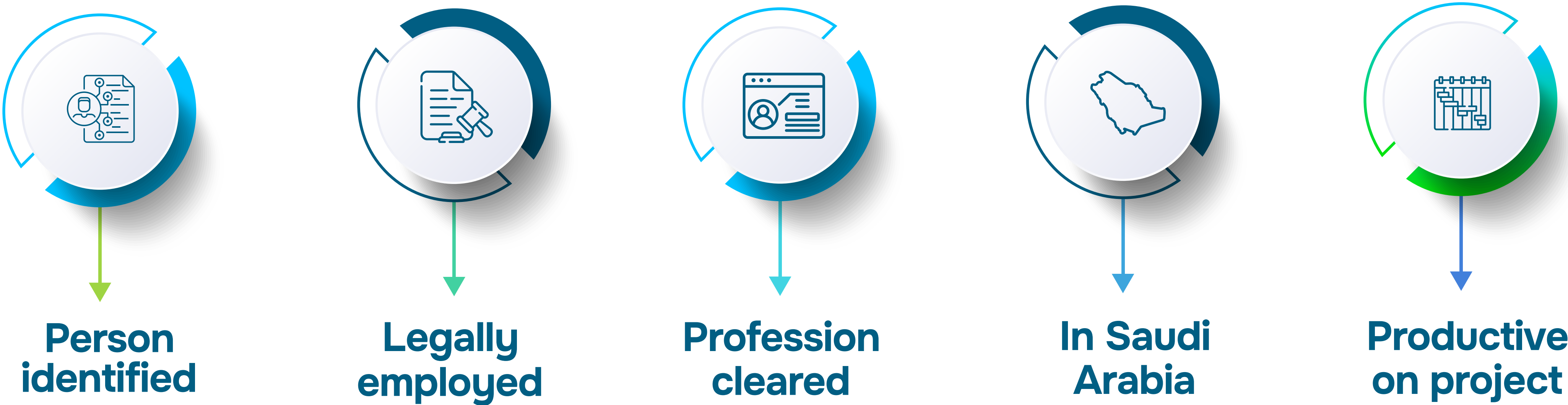
Your Resource Plan Is Not Your Ready Workforce

An EPCM project can have the contract, engineering schedule and technical team identified while still being weeks or months away from having those people ready to work in Saudi Arabia.



Source note: The 30 percent engineering requirement applies to establishments with five or more workers in the covered engineering professions

The Gap



A specialist being available is only the first step.
The project needs them deployable.

Why Workforce Deployment Needs More Planning Now

Saudi Arabia is not closing the door to international expertise. It is making the route more structured, more skills based and more closely connected to national workforce planning.

Work permits now reflect skill

Expatriate work permits are classified as high skilled, skilled or basic. For higher skilled roles, occupation, education, experience, professional requirements and remuneration can affect classification.

Qualifications matter earlier

Professional Verification has expanded across international source markets and covers 1,007 professions. Qualification and experience checks can therefore become part of workforce readiness before deployment.

Engineering localisation is rising

From 30 June 2026, the Saudization rate for covered engineering professions increased to 30 percent for applicable establishments employing five or more people in those professions.

International expertise still matters

The skill classification policy explicitly supports attracting high level international talent and transferring expertise into the Saudi labour market. The requirement is better planning, not the end of international hiring.

Saudi Arabia still needs international expertise. It increasingly expects companies to bring it in through a properly planned workforce model.



The Real Question

The Hard Part Starts After You Name The Specialist

Finding the right person is only one part of deployment. The project still needs a legal, professional and practical route that gets them ready to work.

- ✔ **A project award** does not make the workforce ready.
- ✔ **A signed offer** does not make someone deployable.
- ✔ **A visa** does not always mean someone is ready for the role.
- ✔ **Existing Saudi operations** do not remove occupation and compliance requirements.
- ✔ **A global mobility team** does not always own every Saudi dependency.

The real question is not can we build a pilot?
It is: What has to happen before this person can actually start the work?

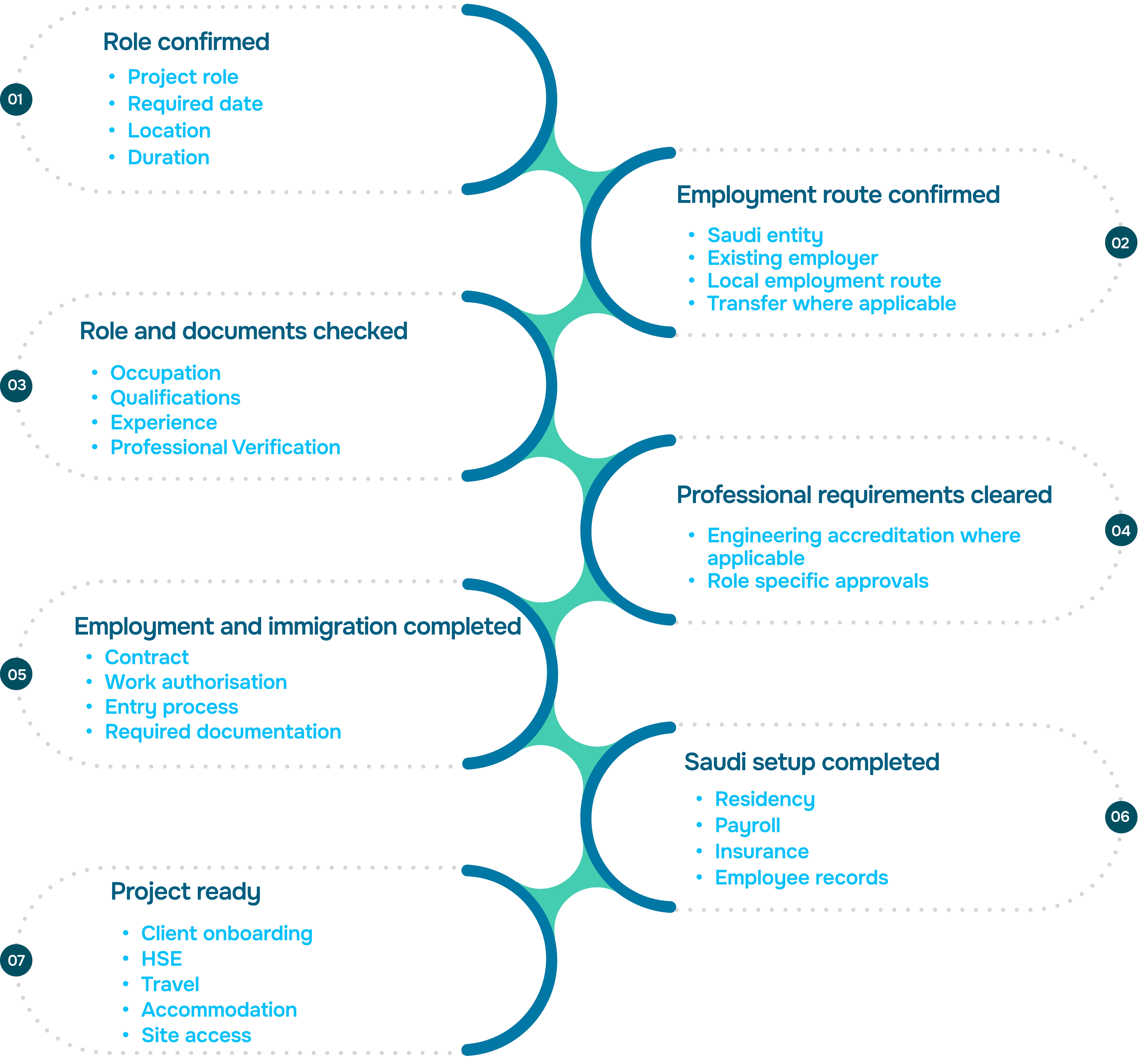
THE FOUR QUESTIONS EPCM FIRMS SHOULD ANSWER BEFORE COMMITTING A START DATE

- 01 Who employs them?
Who will legally employ this person in Saudi Arabia?
- 02 What applies to the role?
What occupation, qualification or professional requirements apply?
- 03 What does it affect?
What Saudi workforce requirements does the role affect?
- 04 What sits between approval and work?
What has to happen between approval and productive work?

A name on a resource plan is not the same as a person ready to deliver.

What Actually Happens Between Selection And Work

Workforce deployment is the chain of actions required to take a person from “we need them on the project” to “they can legally and practically start the work.



Deployment is not one process. It is a chain of dependencies.



Seven Deployment Bottlenecks EPCM Firms Discover Too Late

Most delays are not caused by one impossible step. They build when several smaller dependencies are discovered one after another.

The employment route is decided after the candidate

The person is selected first. Only then does the team decide how the role will be employed.

The project title does not match the required occupation

Internal project titles and formal Saudi occupational classifications are not always the same thing.

Qualification issues appear after selection

Degrees, experience records or qualification evidence are checked only after deployment has already started.

Professional accreditation starts too late

Engineering and other regulated professional requirements are treated as admin rather than a deployment dependency.

Saudization is planned separately

International hiring and the Saudi workforce plan move on separate tracks until they collide.

Documents are collected one step at a time

A passport is requested, then a degree, then another certificate. Sequential collection turns days into weeks.

Nobody owns the full deployment clock

HR, mobility, recruitment, immigration and the project team each own a piece, but no one owns the working date.



THE ENGINEERING QUESTION

Your Saudi And International Workforce Plans Are Becoming One Plan

The stronger response to localisation is not simply “use fewer international engineers”. It is to decide which capability must be imported, which can be built locally and how the two work together.



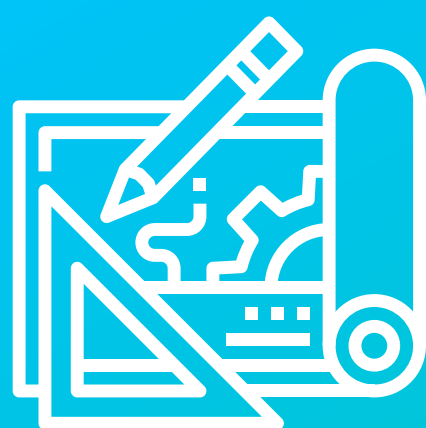
30%

Saudization rate for covered engineering professions



46

Engineering professions covered by the 2026 decision



5+

Engineering employees triggers applicability for covered establishments



340k+

Additional private sector jobs targeted for localisation under the 2026 Nitaqat phase



Most deployment delays are not one big problem. They are several small problems discovered one after another.

THE BETTER QUESTIONS

01 Which expertise genuinely needs to come from outside Saudi Arabia?

02 Which engineering capability already exists locally?

03 Where should Saudi engineers work beside international specialists?

04 Which international roles are temporary capability gaps rather than permanent positions?

The strongest workforce plan solves today’s technical gap without recreating the same gap tomorrow.

Not Every Specialist Needs The Same Route

A project workforce is usually mixed. The route should match the capability gap, the location of the person, the duration of the need and the Saudi workforce plan.

International specialist into Saudi Arabia Best for scarce technical or leadership capability that cannot be sourced locally at project speed. Typical profiles include mining specialists, engineering leads, commissioning experts, project controls specialists and technical directors.	Experienced talent already in Saudi Arabia Useful where transferable capability already exists in infrastructure, industrial, energy or major project environments. Part of the international relocation journey may already have happened, but the correct employment route and occupation still matter.
Saudi talent Best where the role can be sourced locally or where Saudi knowledge creates additional value. Common areas include engineering, procurement, project support, HR, finance, government relations and administration.	Reverse deployment A Saudi employee goes to the company’s global centre of expertise for structured exposure or training, then returns to the Saudi operation. This can help build capability while the wider project scales.

Sometimes the fastest way to bring expertise into Saudi Arabia is to send Saudi talent to where the expertise already exists.

BEFORE THE AWARD

The Deployment Work You Can Do Before You Win The Project

EPCM firms should not start unnecessary mobilisation before a project is awarded. But they also should not start from zero on award day.

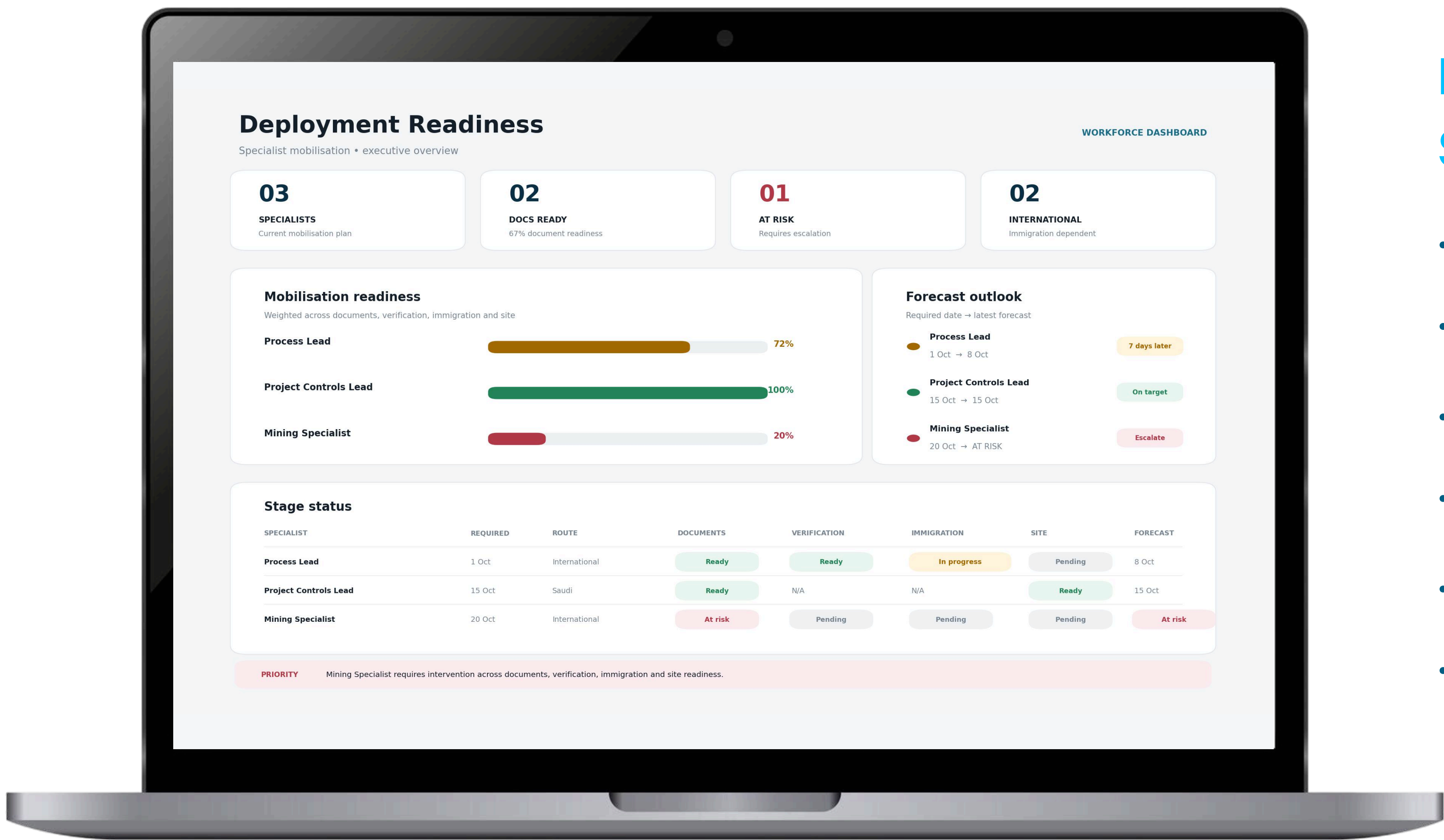
BEFORE AWARD • Map critical roles • Identify likely source countries • Classify Saudi and international capability • Flag regulated professions • Understand likely employment routes • Create document requirements • Map Saudi workforce exposure • Identify backup specialists	AFTER AWARD • Confirm named candidates • Activate employment route • Complete verification • Complete professional requirements • Start immigration process • Complete local employment setup • Coordinate arrival • Complete client and site onboarding
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Do not mobilise before the award. Prepare before the award.

The award should start execution. It should not start figuring out how deployment works.

Put Workforce Deployment On The Project Plan

The simplest improvement is to stop treating deployment as a private HR workflow and start reporting it as part of project control.



LEADERSHIP SHOULD SEE

- Required working date
- Forecast working date
- Current blocker
- Blocker owner
- Days at risk
- Backup route

Stop reporting where the visa is. Start reporting when the person will be productive.

THE COST OF DELAY

One Late Specialist Can Hold Up More Than One Person

The real cost of a slow deployment is often everything sitting behind the delayed specialist, not the specialist alone.

THE DEPLOYMENT DELAY EQUATION



ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

A critical specialist is delayed by 20 working days. Six people depend directly on that specialist’s decisions. If the blended cost attached to those resources is SAR X per day, the workforce cost alone becomes:

20 days × 6 people × SAR X

That is before client impact, rescheduling, temporary cover, subcontractor disruption or milestone exposure.

The expensive part of a delayed specialist is usually everything waiting behind them.

Is Your Saudi Deployment Plan Actually Ready?

Use this before committing workforce dates into a project schedule or client plan.

STRATEGY

- ☐ Do we know the first critical roles?
- ☐ Are required working dates linked to project milestones?
- ☐ Do we know which roles sit on the critical path?
- ☐ Do we know which capabilities must come from outside Saudi Arabia?

PROFESSIONAL READINESS

- ☐ Have occupations been mapped?
- ☐ Have qualifications been checked?
- ☐ Have verification requirements been identified?
- ☐ Have engineering accreditation requirements been reviewed?

PROJECT READINESS

- ☐ Is arrival coordinated?
- ☐ Are payroll and employee records ready?
- ☐ Are client onboarding and site access ready?
- ☐ Is there a backup person for critical roles?

EMPLOYMENT

- ☐ Do we know who employs every specialist?
- ☐ Is the employment route ready?
- ☐ Have transfer requirements been checked where relevant?
- ☐ Does the route match the duration of the need?

SAUDI WORKFORCE

- ☐ Have Saudi and international roles been planned together?
- ☐ Do we understand the impact of engineering Saudization?
- ☐ Are there knowledge transfer opportunities?
- ☐ Do we know which capabilities should become local over time?

A deployment plan is ready only when every critical person has a route, a working date, an owner and a backup.

Your Project Should Not Wait For Your People.

Saudi Arabia's project environment needs global engineering capability. The challenge is not simply finding that expertise. It is getting the right person through the right employment, professional and deployment route in time for the project to use them.

FREE EPCM WORKFORCE DEPLOYMENT READINESS REVIEW

Give us your first 20 critical Saudi roles.

- ✔ Which roles present the biggest deployment risk
- ✔ Which professions require early checks
- ✔ Where employment routes need to be decided
- ✔ Which roles can be sourced locally
- ✔ Which roles may need international expertise
- ✔ Where Saudi workforce requirements affect the plan
- ✔ Which people need backup deployment routes
- ✔ What can be prepared before project award

[Request your workforce deployment review](#) ↗

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